

The rules nobody tells you

Decode the Australian job market | Aussie Grad Careers

80% of jobs in Australia are never advertised. If your entire strategy is refreshing Seek, you are competing for the noisiest 20% of the market while the rest gets filled through conversations you are not in.

Why this is not about you

The pattern is always the same. Strong degree, real experience, genuine skills. Three months on Seek, 100 or 200 applications, almost nothing back. And then the conclusion that the problem is the visa, or the lack of PR.

But you almost certainly know someone from your own country, on the same visa, who has a job. So that premise cannot be the whole story. Every job market runs on an operating system: unwritten rules, cultural signals and hiring norms that locals absorb over years through school, casual jobs and family. Nobody explains it to you, and employers assume you already know it. Australia's is different from the UK's, the US's, India's and most of Southeast Asia's and Africa's. That gap is the problem, and it is fixable.

The five rules

1 Relationships are the primary currency

Australian hiring is relationship first. A candidate who arrives through a connection, even a loose one, gets more attention than a stronger unknown from a job board. Networking is not a nice to have, it is the mechanism by which most roles above entry level actually get filled.

2 Cultural fit is assessed from the first touch point

The tone of your email, the structure of your LinkedIn message, your resume layout, your opening line. People are reading for fit from the very first thing you send, consciously and otherwise. This is not about being someone else. It is that every document is a statement about who you are, not only what you have done.

3 Directness with warmth is the register

Australian professional communication is casual by world standards. First names from day one, short emails, informal check-ins. Write like a Victorian era law firm and you read as stiff. Go too casual too fast and you read as unaware. The target is a confident colleague, not an applicant asking for scraps.

4 Your visa is not a deal breaker, but your handling of it can be

Plenty of employers will sponsor the right person. What loses you the role is leading with the visa question, or leaving it so vague that a recruiter hesitates to proceed. Lead with your current work rights, clearly, and the dynamic changes.

5 Initiative and specificity are rewarded

Employers respond to candidates who have obviously done the homework: who reference something specific, who understand the role in context. A generic application reads as disrespectful of someone's time here, more than in many markets. Specificity is how you signal you are serious.

What to do about it

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The numbers worth memorising

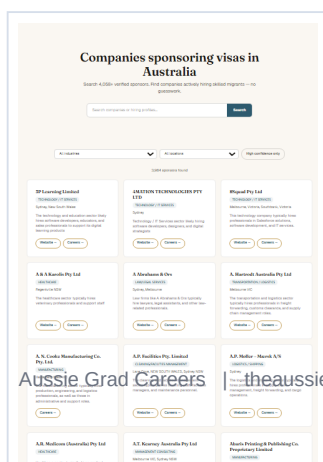
80 / 20	Roughly 80% of roles are filled without ever being advertised. Job boards are the visible fifth of the market.
50 / 30 / 20	How to split your search time: half on outreach and relationships, 30% on applications, 20% on recruiter relationships.
25 a week	Quality, tailored applications. A structured 25 beats 100 random ones almost every time.
7 days	Follow up on every application after seven days of silence. Most candidates never do, which is exactly why it works.
80%	Meet 80% of the criteria and you should apply. Nobody meets 100%, and the people writing the ads know it.
First 48 hours	When most screening happens. Apply the day you see the role.
200 characters	The LinkedIn connection note limit on a free account. 300 on Premium. Write to 200 and it sends either way.
2 pages	Maximum resume length. One page is fine early career.

Do these five things this week

- 1 Rewrite your LinkedIn headline to the job title you WANT, plus two tools and your city. Not the title you just left, and not the word graduate.
- 2 Build a list of 20 to 30 target companies, bookmark each careers page, and set a Google alert for the company name plus the word hiring.
- 3 Send five connection notes to people one or two years ahead of you, at those companies, who share something with you: same university, same home country.
- 4 Rewrite one resume bullet as action plus result plus context. Find the number.
- 5 Set up your tracker and log every application the day you send it.

On sponsorship

Sponsorship is a real path, not a rumour, and thousands of Australian businesses are approved to do it. The mistake is treating it as the first thing you raise rather than something you establish quietly in your targeting. Knowing which employers already sponsor changes where you spend your applications.



The public approved sponsor list runs to thousands of businesses and is published as a raw government file, so it is searchable in principle and unusable in practice. JobHub holds 4,058 of them verified and filterable by industry and location, which turns a target company list into something you build from employers who already sponsor rather than from guesswork. You can do this yourself with the government file and a free afternoon. Most people never do, and that is the only real difference.